

Roasted marinated Mexican tofu steaks

Chiles add an intense and authentic **depth** to the flavor of this Mexican-inspired marinade. When different types of chiles are toasted and hydrated, their flavor profiles run the gamut from hot and smoky to grassy, fruity, and woody. The ideal way to cook this dish is over a hot barbecue. Obviously, this may not always be an option. Second-best choice is to roast at a high heat. Serve with one of my tasty rice side dishes and a salad.

2 pounds tofu, pressed to remove excess water [1kg]

3 ancho chiles

2 New Mexican chiles

1 guajillo chile or 3 New Mexican chiles instead of 2

4 plum tomatoes

2 fresh jalapeño or serrano peppers

1 red bell pepper

3 garlic cloves, minced

2 tablespoons coarsely chopped cilantro, plus more for garnish

Juice of ½ lime

1 teaspoon ground coriander

2 teaspoons unrefined cane sugar

¼ teaspoon cinnamon

1 teaspoon dried oregano, preferably Mexican

2 teaspoons ground cumin

2 teaspoons red wine vinegar

2 teaspoons extra virgin olive oil

1 teaspoon salt

About ¼ cup vegetable stock or water [60ml]

1. **Preheat** the broiler with the rack set 5 to 6 inches [13 to 15cm] from the heat. Slice the tofu into 8 cutlets.
2. In a large dry skillet, **toast** the chiles over medium heat, 1 or 2 at a time, by laying them flat in the pan and pressing down with a spatula for 15 to 30 seconds, until they crackle and give off a slight wisp of smoke. Be careful not to burn them. Flip

over and repeat on the other side. When the chiles are done, submerge them in hot water in a small bowl, cover, and soak until very soft, 30 to 60 minutes.

3. In the meantime, place the tomatoes, jalapeño or serrano peppers, and red bell pepper on a baking sheet. **Broil**, turning with tongs, until blackened all over. They will finish in varying degrees of time. The tomatoes and peppers will slightly char and their skins will blister in 5 to 7 minutes. The bell pepper will probably take 10 to 15 minutes. You want the bell pepper to blacken almost completely.
4. When done, let cool, then **remove** the skins from the tomatoes and the stems from the peppers. You may leave the charred skin on the hot peppers unless it is exceptionally burned. Coarsely chop the tomatoes and the hot peppers, retaining the juices. Scrape the charred skin off the bell pepper, remove the seeds and ribs, and coarsely chop the pepper.
5. In a blender or food processor, **combine** the chopped vegetables with all the remaining ingredients except the tofu and the stock. Puree until smooth, adding enough stock or water to achieve a sauce with the consistency of thick cream.
6. Put the tofu cutlets in 2 large heavy-duty, sealable freezer bags. **Divide** the sauce between the bags, making sure the tofu is well coated. Seal the bags and lay them on a platter or tray. Refrigerate overnight.
7. **Preheat** the oven to 450°F [230°C]. Place the tofu with about half its sauce in an oiled baking dish. Roast for 10 minutes on one side, then 5 minutes on the other. Meanwhile, heat the remaining sauce in a small saucepan on top of the stove or in a bowl in a microwave. Serve the tofu cutlets with the warm sauce. Garnish with chopped cilantro.

SERVES 4 TO 8

note This tofu marinates overnight for maximum flavor. For easier preparation, use canned peeled tomatoes and/or roasted peppers from the deli or your grocery store. Use this recipe to marinate tofu, or modify it slightly and make a sauce simply by omitting the water and pressing the liquid through a fine mesh strainer.

chef's alternative A recipe for Tamarind and Chipotle Sweet-Hot Sauce follows. If you choose, use it to marinate the tofu instead of the Mexican marinade. Cook in the same way.